

merchandise does not cancel the debt, because the finance company has no interest in the merchandise.

Another meaning of *surety* is “One contracted to be responsible for another, especially one who assumes responsibilities or debts in the event of default.”³ The most recognizable form of surety is cosigning for the loan of another person.

4: The borrower has an absolute commitment to repay

In our society, situational ethics are widely accepted, so it is easy to rationalize not paying a debt, especially when the product or service is defective or when one’s financial situation seems to be out of control. In the 1990s and during the first five years of the twenty-first century, easy access to credit led many people to believe that paying their debts would be a snap. Unfortunately, many borrowers discovered that it was possible for them to accumulate far more debt than they could repay and still maintain the lifestyle they wanted. As a result, they bailed out.

For example, in 1999, about 1,500,000 people chose personal, nonbusiness bankruptcy as a way to avoid repayment. Yet the average indebtedness for couples in bankruptcy was only about \$6,300. Due to changes in the bankruptcy law in 2005, it is not as easy to file for bankruptcy today. Still, people who are getting in over their heads may continue overspending, believing that somehow they will qualify for bankruptcy.

You may even hear some Christian teachers draw a parallel between modern law on bankruptcy and the year of jubilee prescribed by God: “Consecrate the fiftieth year and proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants. It shall be a jubilee for you; each one of you is to return to his family property, and each to his own clan” (Leviticus 25:10).

I wish I could support the view that the year of jubilee and voluntary bankruptcy are comparable, but they aren’t. Voluntary bankruptcy is an act by a borrower to avoid his or her creditors. The